Four Good Days - Screenplay

By Eli Saslow and Rodrigo Garcia

Suggested Roles: ***Actress 1:*** *Molly* ***Actress 2:*** *Mom, Nurse, Doctor*

NOTE: This cutting asks one student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO in your state! Be sure to check your STATE rules before performing at local tournaments.

MOLLY: *(knocking on door, she is in rough shape)* Mom, it's me. *(knocking)* Mom! *(trying her key in the lock)* Uh, my key doesn't work.

MOM: No, we, uh. . . We changed the locks last year after you and Eric stole the guitars. The deal was you wouldn't come back until you were clean.

MOLLY: *(gasps)* Wait, wait, wait. *(stuttering)* That is why I'm here. I'm . . . I'm done. I wanna come home. I ended it with Eric. He's gone. I've been thinking about all the things that you said to me since I was a little girl and I've had these, like, realizations like, these big, big realizations that I wanna go back to school and I wanna get a job and I wanna get my kids back. . .

MOM: Molly, stop. Just stop. I've heard this speech for 10 years.

MOLLY*: (crying)* Mom, I need to be home.

MOM: *(resolute)* No. Come back when you're clean.

MOLLY: No, Mom, please. *(knocking intensifies)* It's me! *(Mom opens the door, but doesn't allow Molly in)*

MOM: Don't make me call the police.

MOLLY: Just money for a hotel then. I need some place safe that I can get clean.

MOM: You want me to give you money? Are you crazy? Like the money you needed for shoes or for glasses? Or for, uh, oh, online cosmetology classes? How much heroin have I paid for?

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MOLLY: *(sudden anger; she tries a guilt trip)* You're right. I'll just detox under a highway with prostitutes and rats, 'cause that's a much better plan, Mom. *(quick change of emotion to tears again)* Can I please just have a pillow and a blanket? It gets really cold at night.

MOM: If you're hoping for pity, there's none coming. *(beat, sighs in frustration)* Oh, God damn it. If you're serious, I'll drive you to detox right now.

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *On the verge of collapse, Molly shows up at her mother's house seeking help.*
ACTRESS 2: *Ten painful years of estrangement, drug use, and addiction have taken a toll on their already fragile relationship.*
ACTRESS 1: *You see, Molly has been through detox more than a dozen times, yet the brutal heroin addiction shows no signs of waning.*
ACTRESS 2: *Research advancements may offer Molly a shred of hope--a monthly shot of an opioid antagonist that prevents toxic substances from binding to the central nervous system.*
ACTRESS 1: *But, there's a catch: Molly must stay clean for four excruciating days to receive the treatment.*
ACTRESS 2: *Can Molly go the distance this time?*
TOGETHER: *Four Good Days by Eli Saslow and Rodrigo Garcia*

NURSE: Name?

MOLLY: Molly Wheeler Margaret

NURSE: What drugs are you using?

MOLLY: *(nonchalant)* Heroin, methadone and some crack.

NURSE: Have you ever been through detox?

MOLLY: *(almost proudly)* Fourteen times.

NURSE: Mm-hmm. Okay, so you know the drill. Medicaid pays for three nights. You get a cot, two towels, three meals a day, if you can tolerate them. Muscle spasms, cold sweats, fever, vomiting, paranoia, insomnia. All that's normal. But if you start to have trouble breathing, speak up. Sign here.

MOLLY: *(to Mom)* Okay. You've made your point. Can I please come home now?

MOM: No. I'll pick you up in three days. *(turns to exit)*

MOLLY: Really? You're not gonna help? *(crying)* You're gonna walk away?

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MOM: *(steps out of scene to speak to the audience – matter-of-factly)* She's in hell right now. In pain from head to toe and I kicked her to the curb. *(sighs softly)* Sometimes I get the feeling that. . . I don't want to love her anymore.

*****The Detox Exit interview*******

DOCTOR: I'm gonna level with you, Molly, because you don't have time for more bull. Heroin has a 97 percent relapse rate. You've already blown through the veins in your arms, your ankles, hands, feet. Yeah, you stayed away from your neck so far, but most people go there sooner or later. You have put yourself in quite a situation. What are your triggers?

MOLLY: Boredom, anxiety, shame, loneliness. My life. Basically, my life's a trigger. I'm 31 years old, and I've done nothing but go down in life. So I can sit around and feel all of that, or I can do something about it and feel good and numb.

DOCTOR: Let's talk about our options. Hmm? Do you know what an opioid antagonist is? It's a shot we give you once a month. It blocks opioids from getting into your system. Heroin, Oxy, Narcotics. The shot essentially makes you immune to getting high.

MOLLY: Is it safe?

MOM: Are you kidding me? You've spent 10 years shooting up heroin laced with what, rat poison and baby powder and God knows what else. And now, all of a sudden, your body's a temple. Is it safe? Jesus, Molly.

MOLLY: It's my call Mom . . .

DOCTOR: Yes, it's safe. FDA approved. You have to be clean for at least a week. If you still have drugs in your system when you get this shot, it puts you into something called rapid withdrawal. That's very dangerous. Emergency room stuff.

MOLLY: *(sighs)* Fine. Yeah, okay.

DOCTOR: You have been in detox four days already. You should do four more to be safe.

MOLLY: Four more days?

DOCTOR: You need to be somewhere not alone and away from other users . . .

*******At Mom's house *******

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MOLLY: *(to audience as Mom is doing some activity in the background)* I'm always thinking about the past or worrying about the future. You know, even before I did drugs, I remember worrying about what was next. Like, I just couldn't live with the uncertainty. I just want now to be now. *(long pause-steps into scene with Mom and speaks to her)* [Remember] the time you left for, like, *(air quotes)* a couple of weeks. It was just so sudden. You know, one day you were. . . putting notes in my lunch box, and then the next, you disappeared on your little two-year hiatus. I thought you couldn't stand to be around us, around me.

MOM: That wasn't it. You know that's not true. I got pregnant with your sister. Unplanned. And in a couple of months, I found myself with a baby, and I quit my job, and I was married to a man who I really didn't know very well, and he was. . . *(sighs)* He was difficult. And when your sister was eight, I got pregnant again and we were really happy about that. We were. . . I think we were at a pretty good point. Me and your dad, you know, for a moment. Then for 15 years, I held everything together. . . trying not to disappoint, swallowing your father's temper tantrums, his moods. And then one night I came home and I heard him start to rev up one of his fits. . . and I just. . . That was it. I left that night.

MOLLY: You were the head of the PTA. You were so put together.

MOM: I was pretending. *(scoffs)* I just. . . I am so sorry for causing you so much pain, but I can't apologize for trying to survive. I just can't. That would be lying. *(long beat)* You think it's my fault you're an addict. *(Molly shrugs and exits; Mom to audience)* She sits around smoking, twitching, and I am there watching her like a hawk and pretending that I'm not. Pale, thin. Toothless. But, you know, pretty damn good under the circumstances. I think she might make it this time. If she can only hang on for a couple more days. Then she could get the shot, and one month clean will turn into two months and two months into six.

******AA Meeting******

MOLLY: *(speaks to the audience)* So, I, uh. . . I was a straight A student who never graduated high school. I live at home with my mom, but last week I was sleeping on the streets. Don't have a job. Or any job skills or a dollar to my name. See that, um, that lady in the back. It's my mom. She drove me here today because I, uh. . . my license was suspended because of so

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many DUIs. But even if I did have my license, she wouldn't trust me with her car. Because I have. . . I have robbed her blind. Money, jewelry, credit cards. And I have. . . degraded myself for drugs, in ways. . .in ways that you don't want to know. *(she hears a comment from the audience and responds)* Excuse me? Do you know how many times I have told myself that? That I'm not going to let myself steal to get high? That I'm not gonna let myself lose custody of my children to get high? That I'm not gonna let myself stab a needle into my arm? I'm so sorry, Mom.

MOM: *(after the meeting)* I haven't seen you like that for so long. Confident, honest. Taking full responsibility. Just. . . I don't know. Just being yourself. You should have seen the way they were looking at you. Just riveted. If there's anyone who has the strength to break free of this, it's you. I really believe that. *(long beat)* You know, I've been wanting to ask you something, but I do not want you to take it in the wrong way. I just. . . No judgement. Did you ever. . . prostitute yourself?

MOLLY: I never had sex for money, but I have had sex for drugs.

MOM: Well, that's not prostitution. No, That's, uh, a sick person trying to survive.

MOLLY: *(picking a fight)* Yeah, but if I had had sex for money to buy drugs, would that make me a prostitute? So, what's the verdict, Mom? Whore? Not whore? *(Molly's phone vibrates and she answers; her words ring false)* Yeah, this is Molly. We already scheduled the shot for 9:00 am Friday. No! No, I can't wait. Are you serious? Yeah, we'll see you on Monday.

MOM: Okay. So what was that?

MOLLY: Three more days. They're waiting for my insurance papers to go through.

MOM: Three days is an eternity.

MOLLY: Jesus. You're not helping. *(growling in frustration)*

MOM: *(suspicious)* Why didn't I hear your phone ring?

MOLLY: What?

MOM: *(growing anger as she realizes Molly is lying)* Your phone? Why didn't I hear it ring? And why is the office still open. It's after 6 o'clock. I want to see your phone. Give me your phone.

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MOLLY: Are you crazy?

MOM: How many fake phone calls have you made? Lies from the very beginning.

MOLLY: Are you doing this to me right now? Oh, my God. You're such a trigger!

MOM: *(angrily)* It just goes on and on.

MOLLY: I am so sorry that my drug addiction is so incredibly difficult on you. Look, I, I am not going to make it to Monday if I stay here. I'm gonna go to Sean's, I'm gonna go stay with Sean. He. . . he said that he can pick me up.

MOM: The same Sean who wanted you to score for him? Do you hear yourself? I mean, do you hear yourself? Do you? *(washes her hands of the situation)* All right. Do what you're gonna do. *(Molly exits, Mom talks aloud to herself, contemplating)* How did I get here? What did I do? You know, maybe it's just the way her brain is wired. You know? Maybe she'd taken the pills the year before, or a year after, she wouldn't have gotten hooked. Or if you'd stayed in your bad marriage, she would have been an even bigger addict. Or if you bought her those blue shoes that time when she was three, instead of the red. It's none of that . . . Because maybe, the moment her father's sperm reached your egg, she was already an addict, waiting to happen.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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**** the full transcript of the screenplay can be found on Scraps from the Loft.com at https://scrapsfromtheloft.com/movies/four-good-days-transcript/***

AWARD HISTORY

2024 National Qualifier
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